A Stakeholder-Aware CEO Playbook

This note turns the classic "drastic changes" table into a compact decision model. Each executive action is represented in three ways: (1) as a business action, (2) as a set of COCOMO-style driver changes, and (3) as a source of stakeholder tension.

1. Stakeholder space

Stakeholders are located in a four-dimensional space using a five-point scale. At one end of each dimension is a lightweight, local preference; at the other is a more strategic or controlling preference.

Dimension	0	4
Now	Now	Later
Build	Use	Build
Change	Stable	Change
Control	Autonomy	Control

Table 1: Stakeholder dimensions (0–4 scale).

Group	Now	Build	Change	Control
Users	0	0	1	0
Customers	1	0	1	2
Developers	1	4	3	0
QA	2	2	1	3
Managers	3	2	2	4
Executives	4	3	4	4
Regulators	4	0	0	4
Ops	1	3	0	2

Table 2: Canonical stakeholder groups in the 4D space.

An organization is modeled as a weighted mix of at most three groups, e.g. customers:developers:executives = 1:2:2. Its organizational preference vector is the weighted centroid of those groups.

2. Drastic actions and the knobs that implement them

The action table should not be bland. Each row should say what an executive move means in operational terms. The table below keeps the spirit of the original: each drastic business action is tied to concrete driver changes.

#	Drastic change	Effects (COCOMO drivers pushed)
1	Improve personnel	acap=5; pcap=5; pcon=5; aexp=5; plex=5; ltex=5
2	Improve tools, techniques, or development platform	tool=5; time=3; stor=3; pvol=2; site=6
3	Improve precedentedness / development flexibility	prec=5; flex=5
4	Increase architectural analysis / risk resolution	resl=5
5	Relax schedule	sced=5
6	Improve process maturity	pmat=5
7	Reduce functionality	data=2; cplx=2
8	Improve the team	team=5
9	Reduce quality	rely=1; docu=1; time=3; cplx=1

Table 3: Implementing drastic changes via driver settings.

3. The same actions seen as social tensions

Every action also has a political signature. For each row, there is some group most likely to welcome the move and some group most likely to resist it. That opposition can be summarized as a main tension in the 4D space.

#	Action	Most likes	Most hates	Main tension
1	Improve personnel	Executives, managers	Staff, unions, weak performers	Control vs Autonomy
2	Improve tools / platform	Architects, innovators	Legacy maintainers, conservative ops	Change vs Stability
3	Improve precedentedness / flexibility	Strategists, R&D	Regulators, fixed-plan customers	Change vs Control
4	Increase risk analysis	QA, architects, regulators	Developers under delivery pressure	Control vs Autonomy
5	Relax schedule	Developers, QA	Sales, impatient customers	Build vs Use
6	Improve process maturity	QA, managers, auditors	Developers, agile teams	Control vs Autonomy
7	Reduce functionality	Developers, maintainers	Customers, sales, product owners	Build vs Use
8	Improve the team	Leadership, strong contributors	Politically entrenched or low performers	Control vs Comfort
9	Reduce quality	Short-term sales, speed-focused executives	Users, QA, support	Now vs Later

Table 4: Each action is also a stakeholder conflict.

4. Decision rule

We optimize for: *minimize change, maximize delivered value, minimize effort, and minimize risk.* But an action is not acceptable just because it scores well on those objectives. An action may still trigger alarms if it moves too close to a group's negative concerns.

A simple model is:

$$score(a) = w_1\, change(a) + w_2\, effort(a) + w_3\, risk(a) - w_4\, value(a)$$

for action a, subject to stakeholder constraints:

$$pain(g, a) \leq \tau_g \quad foreachstakeholdergroupg$$

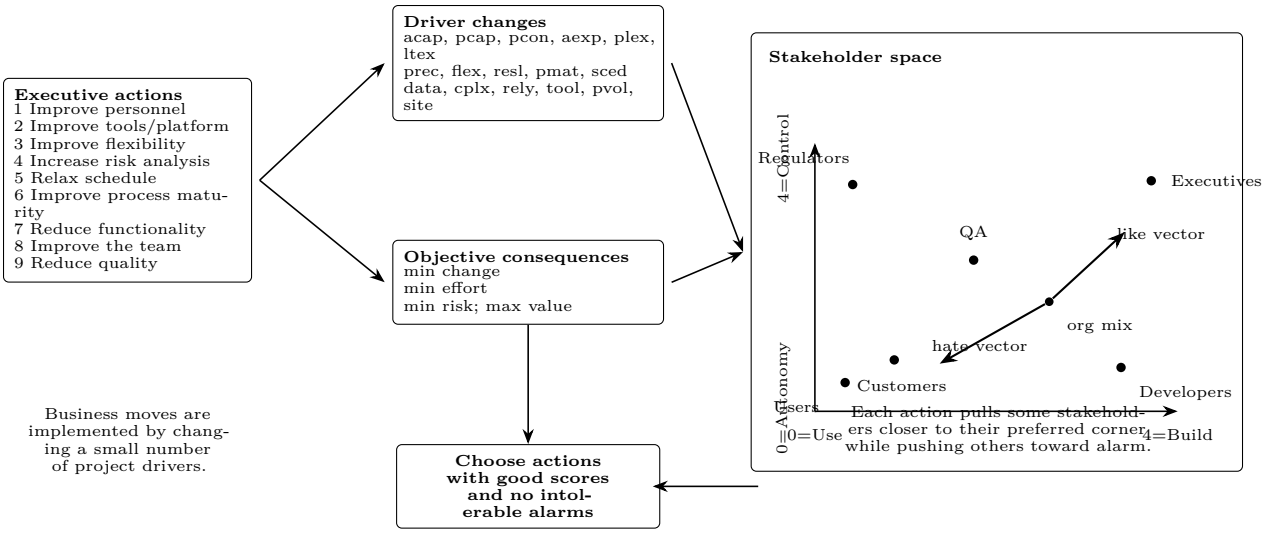

Figure 1: From executive actions to driver changes, objective consequences, and stakeholder alarms. The right-hand panel shows a 2D proxy (Build×Control) for the larger 4D stakeholder space.

where τ_g is that group's tolerance threshold. In words: choose good actions, but reject actions that make some constituency scream too loudly.

5. A single killer figure

Figure **??** ties the whole story together. An executive chooses an action. That action changes concrete project drivers. Those driver changes produce objective consequences (cost, effort, risk, value) and social consequences (who likes it, who hates it). The chosen decision is therefore not just "the best" move; it is the best move that does not trigger unacceptable alarms.

6. Summary

The point of the model is simple:

> Actions move systems.
> Driver changes implement actions.
> Distances measure stakeholder pain.
> Good decisions are those with strong objective scores and tolerable social cost.